

# SALTING THE EARTH: *Organizing for the Long Haul*

*There is no better way to gain an understanding of the needs, fears and beliefs of workers than to work and experience an organizing drive side by side with them. During my time as an inside organizer, I played an important role in organizing workers and gained invaluable insight into the psychological and interpersonal dynamics of uniting personalities into a single voice for change.*

– Richard Bensinger, Former Executive Director, AFL-CIO Organizing Department

The concept of the inside organizer, or “salt,” is a frequently unrecognized but essential part of the American labor tradition. The Knights of Labor had them. The Wobblies had them. The mass labor uprisings in the 1930s were partially the result of men and women who entered various industries to organize. The same can be said for the late 1960s and 1970s. (Although this article will not thoroughly survey the history of salting, we note that to date no monograph exists on this topic—though it should!) In every era in the history of the American labor movement where militancy flared, there existed organizers within the ranks agitating for rebellion.

Given the current climate and energy within the labor community over organizing, we feel it is time to evaluate the role of salts in

the labor movement. The current organizing system is effective insofar as it is somewhat successful at bean-counter organizing, where a union is concerned only with increasing its numerical strength and not its mobilization or participatory capacity. Most of the organizing done by AFL-CIO affiliates today fails to encourage the sort of mass militancy necessary to transform the labor movement into a force for social change. Salting is thus relevant because it promotes the kind of rank-and-file-driven organizing that leads to a mobilized and active membership. The current models of organizing, heavily reliant upon staff organizers and virtually incapable of developing rank-and-file leadership, only help to reinforce the seemingly universal notion that unions are self-concerned and

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myopic insurance agents.

In the hopes of echoing the more militant tradition of organizing, we serve as two of the several organizers who entered the ranks of the same day courier industry in the San Francisco Bay Area. Workers in this industry began to show signs of interest in union organization in the late 1990s. Like most other nonunion workers in service industries, messengers receive little respect from their bosses, make low wages, have poor health benefits (if any at all), work long hours without receiving their legally entitled overtime, and endure terrible working conditions (riding a bike all day in city traffic is bad enough, but because the majority of companies pay by the package, messengers are rewarded for riding as fast as they can).

Under the strategic direction of the International Longshore and Warehouse Union (ILWU), we sought jobs in those companies most likely to organize and most likely to provide industry leverage once they were under a union contract. Comprised of a handful of large companies, the industry is responsible for delivering the bulk of correspondence and legal documents too urgent or too labor intensive to be left to the post office. Messengers not only carry documents across town in a flash, but they wait in the appropriate lines at court or at the bank to make the last minute legal filing or deposit. While bike messengers are responsible for the bulk of intracity deliveries, driver messengers

spend most of their day on Bay Area freeways toting correspondence and the like from one end of the peninsula to the other. Although bike messengers are more visible, drivers outnumber the bikes ten to one. In addition, the drivers perform the more profitable deliveries as determined by weight and distance.

As bike messengers, access to fellow workers was relatively easy because most bike messengers congregate on the job, as well as after work to share work stories and beers. Once mutual respect and camaraderie were established, we had an easy time putting across persuasive arguments for unionizing. The role of salts in this type of an organizing scenario, as we've learned by experience, is indispensable. First and foremost, salts have a level of access to the workforce targeted by the union that a staff organizer could only wish for. This, of course, is because the salt is doing the work, and in many industries (though not all) this means interaction at a more integrated level with co-workers than staff are able to achieve. In industries where co-worker interaction is rare, a salt is still apt to have better opportunities to discuss unionism with workers than the staff organizer, simply because workers tend to trust the opinions of co-workers more than anyone else on work-related topics.

The economic power in the industry is wielded by the driver messengers who do not congregate at all. Because driver messengers in the Bay Area are constantly in motion, flying down freeways from one corner of the region to another, the only person with whom they regularly communicate is their dispatcher, and then by radio. Organizing drivers is like herding cats, and to date our success in getting them to participate in the drive has involved visiting them at their houses. Certainly the staff organizers work-

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ing on this campaign have done an excellent job in recruiting drivers into the unionizing effort, but even they observe that a fellow worker resonates much better than a “staff

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hack.” Where a staff organizer gets the door slammed in his face or a curt, “I don’t need a union,” a salt, in his or her capacity as a fellow worker, will have a meaningful conversation about the pros and cons of unionism.

In analyzing our experience as salts, it seems obvious to us that the camaraderie we enjoy with those we are organizing is born out of shared experience (based specifically around the work we have in common) and social bonding. For all messengers, and especially for the bike messengers, the work is extremely dangerous, physically exhausting, and psychologically taxing. All of us are berated and “disciplined” by our supervisors and dispatchers for little or no reason, oftentimes belittled on the radio for the benefit of all to hear. Office buildings to us are fortresses where we are not always welcome, meaning we must use the rear entrance, sign in and out, show identification, and in some cases be shepherd to our destination. (These obstacles have become notoriously worse since September 11, and are general reminders for all service workers in downtown areas across the nation that they are at the bottom of the social ladder.) The result of such occupational oppression and danger is an intense respect for one another, which in San Francisco has manifested itself in a true community of interest among the bike messengers.

The second component of the camaraderie we have experienced while messengering is the social bonding. In fact, it is virtually impossible to determine where the shared work experience ends and social bonding begins. We bond socially when we are at work as we stand by waiting for tags. Yet many working in the industry would not have thought of being messengers without having met at some cultural gatherings, such as punk shows or parties. (The messenger world in San Francisco operates on the fringes of a number of young and rebellious cultural movements.)

Indeed the social aspect and the work experiences reinvent themselves as part of each other. As salts, we are committed to enduring the same poverty, disrespect, and dangerous working conditions as our fellow messengers. But we also recognize that the social and cultural elements are just as important if not the same thing: giving personal advice, offering a couch to crash on, loaning money, and drinking ourselves legless are all a part of instinctive bonding among fellow workers. In our opinion, a salt is, well, not worth his own salt if the relationships he builds with his co-workers are not real friendships independent of the union organizing. Without the support and friendship of our co-workers, many of whom will never know that we got jobs as messengers to organize, we would not have found salting sustainable.

Salting is not a form of labor activism that everyone can sustain. The drawbacks can be debilitating. Working in nonunion sectors usually means low pay, long hours, and horrendous working conditions. Adding the ever present stress of organizing, including the after work or weekend meetings, the constant

fear of being found out and fired by your boss is enough to topple even the most stable mind.

Also, finding an industry to plug into is not always easy. We just happened to be rather athletic young men who like punk rock and beer, and therefore we happened upon one hell of a community, which with our help is finding and developing its power. But our industry is obviously not for everybody, just like salting a sweatshop would not be for us.

Clearly, potential salts are limited to some degree in terms of which industries they can help organize by their background. Although we have not experienced difficulty as salts due to our white ethnicity or our middle-class backgrounds, it is not hard to imagine that this could be a difficulty in other industries. Two college educated, leftist, white guys don't stand out as much as they might elsewhere because the majority of bike messengers in San Francisco are male, white, single, and between the ages of eighteen and thirty. The drivers, on the other hand, are more likely to be first generation immigrants with families and mortgages, and less likely to be part of the messenger social scene. Many drivers come from Mexico, Central America, China, and South Asia.

More important than class background and ethnicity in our particular experience is language. Being able to speak in terms or tongues that your co-workers understand is of primary importance. The fact that we shared a lot in common culturally with messengers allowed us to adapt to other elements of the job, like the occupational danger, which might not have been possible without that already existing cultural bond and the community it affords. Although the work we do is sometimes physically painful and

painfully monotonous, the tight community keeps us going. It's all about finding a job that is strategically important, organizable, and sustainable.

Regarding sustainability among young labor activists, specifically organizers, if we as a labor movement are genuinely bent on not replicating corporate culture, we must alter our practices. Recruiting college graduates, putting them through boilerplate training, and then bouncing them across the country from one organizing drive to the next is not conducive to keeping young organizers in the labor movement. Serious consideration needs to be given to different elements of support—from the union, other organizers, and possibly cadre if the young organizer is politically motivated. The added beauty of

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salting is that the salt can rely on all of these, and also another support network, namely his friends on the job.

Salting promotes more effective organizing. It is hard to proceed from this statement without some clarification of what effective organizing is. Unfortunately, too many believe that organizing is about numbers. The focus is on density, and one often hears labor leaders intoning the notion that, "Labor now represents less than 14 percent of the American workforce. Unless we organize, further decline—indeed extinction—is at hand." This is at best a half-truth. The fundamental equation within the realm of indus-

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trial relations is that of power. Though labor's numbers have some representational quality in relation to its power in the society, what is more important is the degree to which its ranks are mobilized enough to threaten the foundations of an economy driven by the bottom line.

Effective organizing starts with the conscious decision by union leaders, within internationals and locals, to organize-knowing full well that the new members will have a democratic say in the union's life. The potential threat to the leadership's base from newly organized and politicized workers scares many a union leader from practicing the arts of democracy, specifically when it comes time to organize. It is our experience, however, that leaders who promote democracy in organizing are generally championed, not challenged. Also, institutional leadership, as opposed to the rank-and-file kind, should not be encouraged in the labor movement.

Next, the union must target industries pivotal to the economy in their region, and determine if they can muster enough leverage to be successful. Staff organizers then make contacts with workers in these industries and begin the process of leadership development, determination of workers' issues, and inoculation against the employer's coming onslaught. From there on, the organizing drive should be in the hands of the workers, with the staff organizers helping to form strategy.

For example, the same day urgent delivery messengers in San Francisco analyze their industry and formulate organizing strategy through the Courier Organizing Group (COG). COG is composed of those rank-and-file messengers who are most devoted to organizing. The messengers set the agenda, run the meeting, and through the course of the meeting come to consensus on what form the next three month's strategy will take (COG meets quarterly). Also present at COG meetings are ILWU International organizers

and Warehouse Local 6 elected officers whose role as advisors is key, for they have much valuable experience to share. However, deliberations in this body follow the traditional ILWU method: the rank and file makes decisions, and the attending labor bureaucrats help to carry them out.

Where theory meets practice head on is in finding a union that is infrastructurally equipped to work with salts. Notice we do not say, "equipped to use salts." To us this is an important distinction. A union that uses a salt as it would a staff organizer, where the activist is given instructions and must toe the line of the union's organizing policy, is not organizing members for participation. Instead, the union's organizing department must show the salt respect by inviting his synopsis of the situation and strategizing with him about the details of the drive.

Of primary importance should be leadership development and the mobilization of the workers to the extent that a committee is created, which runs the drive with the help of the staff organizers, not as their stooges. We believe that salts can be especially useful in the promotion of rank-and-file leadership, for by showing it themselves, they will, for a number of reasons indicated above, magnetize leaders from the rank-and-file to the drive. But to accomplish their work, salts need the backing of a union whose infrastructure is such that they hunger for the vibrant new members that a democratic organizing drive will produce. These new members, probably having just fought like hell to get into the union, will have the skill base and understanding of class conflict to breathe new life into stale and shrinking unions, both in terms of internal and external organizing.

If the leadership of the union fears such members, they will (by definition) be incapable of supporting the salt in any meaningful way—instinctively "knowing" that the salt's role is to undermine the leader by bringing in

new potential challengers to the status quo of the union. Hence the importance of the phrase “change to organize, organize for change.” Internal transformation must occur before external organizing of any worth is possible, yet bringing in new members through rank-and-file organizing drives will force internal change.

The American labor movement is currently in crisis due mainly to its unwillingness to change. Though in the past few years

it has embarked on an unprecedented effort to win back numbers, the labor movement has not honestly attempted massive transformation. We believe that systematic salting of key industries can force changes in the labor movement, specifically around the question of how best to organize. The democratic inflection that salting promotes in an organizing drive can ring to the core of any industry or union. ■